IN THE CENTER of the continent, the kingdom of Kanem was at its zenith.

Dunama, the first royal convert to Islam, had not managed to bring all of his people into the fold behind him. But his descendant and namesake Dunama Dibalemi, ruling from sometime in the early 1220s and staying in power until 1259, took more direct action. He first requested, and then ordered, his people to abandon their traditional practices and follow the ways of Islam; and then, to make his point, he destroyed Kanem's most precious religious object.[6]

"In the possession of the Saifawa [dynasty]," an Arab account tells us, "there was a certain thing wrapped up and hidden away, whereon depended their victory in war. It was called *Mune* and no one dared to open it. Then the sultan Dunama . . . wished to break it open. His people warned him, but he refused to listen to them. He opened it, and whatever was inside flew away."[7]



41.1 Zagwe, Kanem, and Mapungubwe

The exact nature of the *mune* is never made clear, but this was part of its power. The sacred object required obscurity for its power. Veiled, it was potent. Unveiled, trivial. Dibalemi ripped away its secrecy.

He had no need for talismans to give him victory in war. Dibalemi was good at war. He spent the early years of his reign building up his cavalry